Day' asking Soviet armed forces to be ready to go into action against 'any imperialist aggression'.

Despite the agitation, Khrushchev's ultimatum deadline for the Allies to quit Berlin on 27 May 1959 was dialled back, but nobody was deluded into thinking the matter was dead. Khrushchev's posture of restraint came after the Soviet Union achieved several key distinctions that year, such as becoming the first nation in space, the first to place a satellite in solar orbit, and the first to crash a missile on the moon, achievements which left American self-confidence badly shaken.

While these momentous events were transpiring in the Soviet Union, Honecker keenly followed a series of anti-Semitic events in the FRG, including the defacement of a synagogue in Cologne by two members of the right-wing 'Reich party', a political clique regarded as a revival of the Nazi Party. While demands were made in Bonn to ban the movement, Adenauer left the party alone. His blunder proved a Godsend for Honecker and the SED propaganda machine and a huge embarrassment for West Germany. 'Such forces,' noted Neue Zeit, 'could unfold again which, with old slogans, would awaken the "consciousness against the East" and stir up racial hatred.'8 At the same time, in his capacity of defence chief, Honecker muddied the water by accusing the FRG of imperialistic intentions after clumsy attempts by F.J. Strauss, the hamhanded West German defence minister, to obtain bases for the Bundeswehr in Spain. Even Western media described him as 'the man in Bonn who scatters the heaviest Teutonic bricks'.9 As if that wasn't bad enough, Strauss also gave the Kremlin a splendid opportunity to harvest propaganda when he encouraged the Bundeswehr to publish a blimpish pamphlet calling for the arming of the Federal Republic's forces with long-range nuclear weapons.